

EU risks falling behind in commercial drone operations

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【要点】

- ・ EUはドローンの大規模商用運用でAmazonなどの米国企業に遅れており、断片化した国家承認制度と統合的な航空交通管理システムの欠如が障害となっている。
- ・ EU は2021年にドローン規制枠組みを導入し先進的とされているが、各国規制当局が独自要件を設定しているため、ある国での承認が他国では有効にならない。
- ・ 現在、ドローン運用者は限定された区域や廊下に限定されており、複数のドローン運用者と警察ヘリなどの有人航空機が共存する空域運用ができていない。
- ・ 米国は事前に厳格な規制を定めるのではなく、実際の運用から学習して規制枠組みを構築する異なるアプローチを採用している。
- ・ デンマークのドローン航空交通管理企業Skypuzzlerは欧州イノベーション評議会から約250万ユーロの助成金を受け、デジタル航空交通管理プラットフォームを開発している。

【メール原文】

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By TOMMASO LECCA with JORDYN DAHL SNEAK PEEK — The drone sector blames fragment

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By TOMMASO LECCA

with JORDYN DAHL

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SNEAK PEEK

— The drone sector blames fragmented national approvals and the lack of an integrated air traffic system for hobbling EU large-scale commercial drone operations.

— Germany has set its position on the Industrial Accelerator Act, advocating for a broader definition of which countries would count as European.

— Two Belgian courts are expected to deliver rulings next year on a Brussels Airport flight path blamed for causing excessive noise for Brussels residents.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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Mark your calendars: Our weekly mobility calendar landed in your inbox on Thursday. You can also go online to export and plan your week or suggest your own event.

DRIVING THE DAY

EU RISKS FALLING BEHIND IN COMMERCIAL DRONE OPERATIONS: The EU is still far from being able to copy drone operations like Amazon's; its service delivering parcels by drone within an hour of payment is expanding to 500 U.S. cities. Industry representatives blame fragmented national approvals and the lack of an air traffic management system capable of handling multiple drone operators and air traffic simultaneously.

Regulatory leaders: Europe was among the first to establish a regulatory framework for drones, but turning those rules into commercial operations is proving "too complicated," said Jesper Skou, CEO of Danish drone air traffic control tech company Skypuzzler. EU drone rules entered into force in 2021. The EU Aviation Safety Agency describes them as "the most advanced rules and standards for safe and secure drone operations."

But then "you have national regulators setting other requirements ... so you cannot say that if you are approved in Denmark, then you can automatically go to Germany," Skou told Tommaso. The U.S., he argued, took a different approach: The FAA allowed operators to fly first, learn from real tests and then build the regulatory framework around that experience.

Airspace not ready: Beyond regulatory fragmentation, Skou believes Europe's air traffic management system is still ill-equipped for large-scale drone operations. "Today, the problem is that drone operators, whether Amazon or Google's Wing, are trapped into closed areas or closed corridors," he said. "So, you cannot have an airspace with multiple drone operators and manned aviation like police helicopters."

Possible solution: Skypuzzler, which received nearly €2.5 million from the European Innovation Council for a project concluding this month, has developed a digital air traffic management platform based on algorithms that "will automatically and in real time, de-conflict the flying object," by recommending avoidance maneuvers to drones. "Exactly like air traffic controllers in traditional aviation," Skou said.

Let's compete: A former air traffic controller himself, Skou said Europe's air navigation service providers are monopolies in most EU countries. "It's not healthy over time," he said. "Competition in the low-level [airspace] industry is what we want."

Where are the operators? European ANSPs reject the accusation that they are slowing the sector down. "From an airspace management perspective, the integration of drones is progressing, but the market is still at an early stage of development and demand varies considerably between locations," said Eduardo Garcia, senior manager for future skies at Canso Europe, the lobby representing ANSPs.

Investment first: "Developing and deploying the capabilities required for integration at scale requires significant investment, so services and infrastructure will need to evolve progressively in line with operational demand," he added. ANSPs have been under pressure from airlines for years to improve their performance, hire more controllers and reduce delays.

A lot has been done: According to Garcia, "significant research, development and demonstration activity is already taking place," including projects led by the SESAR Joint Undertaking. Canso has also launched the Complete Air Traffic System Global Council, bringing together the aviation sector to explore how traditional aviation and drones can eventually share increasingly automated airspace.

Meanwhile, the Commission is collecting feedback on its Drone Strategy 2.0, adopted in 2022. Companies, public authorities and citizens have until Sept. 6 to submit comments that will feed into the

strategy's review.

CARS

UBER LAUNCHES AUTONOMOUS RIDES IN EUROPE: Uber on Thursday launched its autonomous vehicle service in Zagreb available on its Uber app. The service combines Pony.ai's autonomous driving technology, Verne's fleet operations and Uber's app. Rides have been available since April through Croatian operator Verne, which owns the fleet of vehicles. The launch marks Uber's first foray into offering autonomous rides in the EU.

Yes, but: The vehicles still have a safety driver in the front seat ready to take over in an emergency. Uber and Verne call it a "phased introduction" with fully driverless operations expected in the future.

Part of a broader strategy: While the announcement marks the first time customers can book a robotaxi in Europe through the Uber app, the ride-hailing company is launching similar partnerships across the Middle East. Earlier this year, Uber launched rides without a safety driver with Chinese autonomous platform WeRide in Dubai. This week, the ride-hailing giant announced a second partnership in Dubai with Chinese tech company Baidu.

What's happening in the EU: Uber and its European competitor Bolt have announced other robotaxi plans, but none have yet taken off. Uber said a pilot program in Madrid will launch later this year. Bolt has a separate pilot in Luxembourg.

Regulatory headache: Launching robotaxis in the EU is not as easy as in the U.S. because the EU follows United Nations rules on autonomous driving, and it's up to each region and city to implement the regulations.

Get a move on: As we scooped earlier this year, a group of European capitals are urging the Commission to make it easier for robotaxis to scale across the EU and move beyond pilot projects.

GERMANY'S POSITION ON THE IAA: The German government set out its position on the definition of a European preference under the Industrial Accelerator Act, calling for "Made with Europe" criteria rather than a tighter "Made in Europe" approach advocated by France, a German economy ministry spokesperson told our colleague Tom Schmidtgen.

No discrimination: "For Germany, it is central to Europe working closely and reliably with its partners and deepening and expanding trade partnerships. Here we must send a clear signal and must not discriminate against our partners," the spokesperson said.

No surprises: The position is in line with a position paper Berlin sent to the Commission in December, which called on the IAA to adopt a "Made with Europe" framework. Local content requirements are woven into the automotive package that will grant automakers flexibility on meeting emissions targets, making the legislation critical to Germany's struggling automotive sector.

Bureaucratic FDI: Germany is also critical of the proposals related to foreign direct investments, saying they are adding "too much bureaucracy." The government also wants to reduce Europe's dependencies in strategic industries and welcomes the idea that companies wishing to invest in Europe in certain industries must create joint ventures.

What's next: EU governments are currently discussing their position on the IAA. The Irish Council presidency shared a draft proposal before the summer break with other capitals, which suggested tying Made in EU criteria to products rather than to countries. Technical discussions are continuing in the

working party, and the topic will also be addressed during the Sept. 24 Competitiveness Council.

AVIATION

BRUSSELS COURT RULINGS ON AIRCRAFT NOISE DELAYED UNTIL 2027: Belgian judges won't rule before 2027 on the future of a Brussels Airport flight path that has drawn complaints from residents in the northern part of the Belgian capital.

The Brussels regional government had sought a fast-track injunction to suspend the RNP 07L route, introduced in 2025 during runway renovation works. But the next hearing before the Brussels court of first instance has been scheduled for January, according to local media Bruzz .

Brussels vs. Brussels Airport: The municipalities of Koekelberg, Ganshoren, Jette, Berchem-Sainte-Agathe, Schaarbeek, Evere and Woluwe-Saint-Pierre have joined the regional government's lawsuit. Molenbeek could also join the case at a later stage. The municipalities argue that the flight path exposes more than 250,000 residents to excessive aircraft noise.

Bilingual justice: A parallel case before the Dutch-speaking court will continue in February. Rulings from both the French- and Dutch-speaking courts are now expected in 2027.

Politics first? Federal Mobility Minister Jean-Luc Crucke has set an Oct. 1 deadline to reach a political agreement on new flight paths, raising hopes that the dispute could be settled politically before the courts deliver their verdicts.

PIT STOPS

Lithuania would consider buying a stake in financially troubled Latvian airline airBaltic, Prime Minister Mindaugas Sinkevičius said Thursday.

Weekly Calendar

Here's a selection of upcoming key events, find the complete Week Ahead online.

Eurocontrol Special meeting of Directors General of Civil Aviation
Aug 27, 2026, 9:00 AM - Aug 28, 2026, 5:00 PM · Chisinau, MD

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